Council, where it was then a nonpermanent member, India took the position that the communist regime should hold the Chinese seat.[120] It also declined to recognize the Paris and Washington-backed Bao Dai regime in Vietnam (the communists were backing Ho Chi Minh). These developments particularly grated because Delhi's voice was considered influential with other Asian states. They left the *New York Times* commenting that Nehru's views on developments in Asia were "less than wise."[121]

Indian policymakers were aware of the consequences of the shift in mood in the US toward India because of Delhi's China policy. Bajpai tried to assure American officials that India was not appeasing China.[122] Privately, he and Pandit, who had moved from Moscow to Washington, discussed the need "to correct the misrepresentation to which India is being subjected."[123] Pandit told Nehru this was critical because India wanted "a charge account" from the US (i.e., aid).[124]

But Acheson was blunt; aid could only be "forthcoming when there is Indian receptivity and our own ability, and constructive purpose to be served."[125] With the administration's ability limited and motivation lacking because of India's unwillingness to play a role in its Asia policy, there was little appetite for aiding India. Pandit conveyed her concern to Bajpai that this American attitude toward assistance and its Asia policy, in turn, were the reasons for growing criticism of the US in India.[126]

The bigger China-related stumbling block in US-India relations, however, was yet to come. After all, other American friends and even allies such as Britain had also recognized communist China. It was US-India interactions over the Korean War, which intensified the Cold War, that drove home the disconnect between US and Indian perceptions of China, as well as their preferred method of dealing with that country.

The Korean War: Seeing Each Other as Spoilers (1950)

Initially, the Korean War increased India's importance in the US. This was partly a result of the strategic reconsideration evident in NSC-68. The document represented a more comprehensive view of US strategy, blurring the line between vital and peripheral interests. Drafted in the first half of 1950, it asserted that "a defeat of free institutions anywhere is a defeat everywhere." This turned Lovett's assertion on its head: the US was now opening the door to underwriting the security of the whole world. Threats